

Music & Drama

Year 9

Cambridge Lower Secondary

Student Manual





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Student Manual · Prime Books

ABOUT THIS BOOK

One year, in five parts. Part one teaches you to read a stave and find Middle C. Part two puts a beat under it and gives you your first songs and your first dance. Part three adds the dotted minim and the singing voice. Part four adds four four, a repertoire and the silences you have to count. Part five puts you in front of an audience. Twenty-nine chapters, 98 numbered topics, four checkpoints, and every stave in the book drawn from the same notes you are asked to play.

Prime Books is the student book series of Prime School.

Music and Drama, Year 9. First edition, 2026.

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Written in British English. Distances are metric, money is in euros and times are given on the 24 hour clock.

This book was written for the pupils of Prime School by the Prime School Music and Drama Department. Every stave printed in it was drawn from a note list that was checked to add up before the page was made, and every scanned destination was opened and confirmed before it was printed.

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The Prime Books Subject Series has been developed under the guidance of the Pedagogical Academic Group for each subject and coordinated by the Pedagogical Team of Prime School.

This publication reflects our shared commitment to academic excellence, educational quality, professional integrity, and the continuous advancement of teaching and learning. Through the collective expertise and dedication of our educators, we aim to provide meaningful and engaging learning resources that support students' academic growth.

We extend our sincere appreciation to the Pedagogical Department and the Content Creation Team of Prime School for their invaluable contributions, dedication, and collaborative efforts in making this publication possible.

◆ HOW TO CHECK THIS BOOK

Everything in these pages can be checked, and the book is arranged so that you can.

- ✓ Every **stave** was drawn by the book from a list of notes, and the counting row underneath it was worked out from that same list. If the counting and the notes ever disagree, the book is wrong, and you should say so.
- ✓ Every **bar** in every printed example was checked to hold exactly the number of beats its time signature demands, before the page existed.
- ✓ Every **square code** leads to a resource that was opened and checked on the day this book was made. No code appears twice, and the full web address is printed beside each one, so the page still works without a device.
- ✓ Every **closed question** has an answer at the back. Open questions have acceptance criteria instead: what a good answer must contain, rather than the words it must use.

If you find something in this book that is wrong, tell your teacher. That is how the next edition gets better.

Introduction: why music and drama are one subject

You can learn what a crotchet is in about forty seconds. Learning to play one, in time, in a room with other people, while somebody watches, takes a year. This book is about the second thing.

Music is written down because sound will not stay still. A tune you sing today is gone tomorrow unless somebody has a way of keeping it, and the way we keep it is a set of marks on five lines that any player in the world can read. Learning those marks is the first half of this year.

The second half is what happens when you stand up. A piece of music does not finish on the page. It finishes in a room, in front of people, at a moment that cannot be paused or done again. Everything that makes that go well is drama: where you stand, how you breathe, whether you look up, what your face does, how long you wait before the first note, and what you do when something goes wrong.

Those two halves are not separate subjects that happen to share a timetable slot. They are one skill met from two directions. A pupil who can read a rhythm but freezes in front of an audience cannot perform. A pupil who is comfortable in front of an audience but cannot read cannot learn anything new without being shown it first. This course insists on both, which is why every chapter of it has a panel called **On your feet** and a panel called **In performance**, even the chapters that look like pure notation.

What you will be able to do by July

By the end of this year you will read the treble stave, find Middle C anywhere, name and write the semibreve, the minim, the dotted minim and the crotchet and their rests, read a time signature, bar a rhythm correctly in two four, three four and four four, and play eleven pieces from notation. You will sing in a group, move in time, learn a dance in eight-count phrases, describe a piece of music in words another person could check, and perform in front of an audience without being told what to do next.

That is a real list, and it is not a long one. This subject rewards doing a small number of things properly rather than a large number of things roughly.

How the year is shaped

The school's scheme of work divides the year with four tests, and this book follows those divisions rather than inventing different ones. Each part ends with a **checkpoint** chapter that tells you exactly what is being asked, in advance, in writing. There are no surprises in this course. If something is in a checkpoint, it is because a chapter taught it and a **Your turn** panel made you practise it.

How to use this book

Read this page once, properly. It will save you an hour later, and it explains the wide margin you are looking at right now.

Every chapter opens with a full page carrying the chapter's number, its title, the one question the chapter answers, the list of what you will be able to do, and the topics in the order you meet them. Inside the chapter, numbered topics run on one after another, so a topic can start half way down a page. The eyebrow above a topic always tells you which chapter and which topic you are in, and the line at the top of the page repeats it.

The wide outer margin is yours. This book is set with a deliberately narrow column of text and a wide margin beside it. That is not a mistake and it is not decoration. Music is a subject you annotate: fingering, a count you keep losing, the bar where you always stop. Write in the margin. A clean music book at the end of a year is usually a book nobody practised from.

The panels, and what each one is for

BEFORE THE DOWNBEAT	One question from your own life, asked before any teaching, so you have an opinion to test.
WATCH ME PLAY IT	One passage worked through slowly, with the reasoning and the counting shown, exactly as a teacher would do it at the instrument.
LISTEN AGAIN	The same music met a second way: by ear when you have met it by eye, or by eye when you have met it by ear. One way round is never enough.
AT THE KEYBOARD	The practice instruction for the piano strand, kept in its own panel so that somebody sitting at an instrument can find it without reading the page.
ON YOUR FEET	The drama and movement task. Voice, body, character and space. Every chapter has one, including the chapters about notation.
IN PERFORMANCE	What changes when somebody is watching: entrances, nerves, staging, the bow, and what to do when a mistake happens in public.
CAREFUL	The mistake most people make here, named before you make it.
FROM THE WINGS	A checked fact about music or theatre that is worth knowing and is not needed for the checkpoint.
YOUR TURN	Numbered practice, with room to write. Closed questions have answers at the back.
GO FURTHER	The stretch, for when the rest was straightforward.

THE REHEARSAL

The chapter project. It is always something performed rather than written.

**WHAT YOU CAN
NOW DO**

The self-check that closes the chapter, with the words it taught.

How to read a stave in this book

Every printed example has the notes on the stave, the **beat count** in monospaced figures directly underneath each note, and, where the piece has words, the words beneath that. The count is not decoration: it tells you which beat of the bar each note falls on, and it was calculated by the book from the same notes you are looking at. Say the count out loud while you play. Every pupil who refuses to do this spends the year unable to explain why they keep speeding up.

◆ DO NOT SKIP THE COUNTING

Counting out loud feels childish for about a fortnight and then it stops feeling like anything at all. Playing without counting feels fine for about a fortnight and then you cannot play with anybody else. Choose the fortnight you would rather have.

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Every unit and every numbered topic in this book, with the page it really starts on.

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PART ONE

Sound on the page

Sound will not stay still. A tune you sing this morning is gone by the afternoon unless somebody has a way of keeping it, and for the last thousand years the way we have kept it is a set of marks on five lines. These four chapters teach you to read those marks, to write them so that a stranger could play them back, and to find on a keyboard the one note everything else in this book is measured from.

The stave, the treble clef and Middle C

Five lines, one clef, and the one note everything else is measured from

THE QUESTION THIS CHAPTER ANSWERS

How does a sound that lasts four seconds get written down so that somebody who has never heard it can play it back?

IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL

- ✓ Name the five lines and four spaces of the treble stave.
- ✓ Say what a clef does, and what the treble clef fixes.
- ✓ Find Middle C on the stave and explain why it needs its own short line.
- ✓ Recognise a semibreve and say how many beats it is worth.
- ✓ Write Middle C as a semibreve so that another player can read it.

THE TOPICS

- 1.1 Where music is written down
- 1.2 The treble clef, and the one note it fixes
- 1.3 Middle C, and the little line it sits on
- 1.4 The semibreve: one sound, four beats
- 1.5 Writing Middle C so another player can read it



LISTEN AND LOOK

teoria, Reading Music: Introduction. The stave, the clef and how a pitch becomes a position on a page. Read it after topic 1.2 and see whether it agrees with you.

www.teoria.com/en/tutorials/reading/

Extension only, and not a substitute for the pages. Ask your teacher before you scan.

● BEFORE THE DOWNBEAT

Hum a tune you know by heart. Now, without singing it again, write instructions that would let somebody who has never heard it play it correctly. You may not use the words "you know, the one that goes". Try for two minutes, then compare with a partner. Keep what you wrote. At the end of this chapter you will look at it again and see which of your instructions music already has a symbol for.

CHAPTER 1 • TOPIC 1.1

Where music is written down

The lesson

Music is written on a **stave**: five horizontal lines with four spaces between them. That is all it is. Everything else in notation is a rule about what to put on those lines and in those spaces.

The stave works because it turns a thing you hear into a thing you can see. Higher sounds are written higher up. Lower sounds are written lower down. If one note is drawn above another, it sounds above it. A pupil who understands only that much can already look at a line of music and say whether the tune goes up or down, which is more than most people in the street can do.

A note is written either **on a line**, with the line passing through the middle of the note head, or **in a space**, sitting between two lines. Those are the only two possibilities, and the difference between them is one step of pitch. Drawing a note that is neither clearly on a line nor clearly in a space is the commonest fault in a beginner's manuscript, and it makes the music unreadable rather than untidy.

Notes that are too high or too low to fit on the five lines are written on short extra lines of their own, called **ledger lines**, drawn only as far as that one note needs. You will meet the most important of them in topic 1.3.

◆ COUNT THE LINES, NOT THE SPACES

Ask somebody how many lines a stave has and a surprising number say four, because they have counted the spaces. Five lines, four spaces. Lines are counted from the bottom upwards, always: the bottom line is the first line, the top line is the fifth.

● ON YOUR FEET

Stand in a line of five, each of you one stave line, lowest at the front. Your teacher calls out a note position: "third line", "second space", "top line". The right person, or the right pair, sits down. Do it fast enough that you stop counting from the bottom every time. This is the same recognition you will need when you are reading at speed, and doing it with your body first makes it stick.

CHAPTER 1 • TOPIC 1.2

The treble clef, and the one note it fixes

The lesson

Five lines on their own do not tell you anything. They tell you that one note is higher than another, but not which notes they are. Something has to fix the whole system to actual pitches, and that something is the **clef**.

A clef is a symbol at the start of the stave that names one line. Once one line is named, every other line and space follows automatically, because the musical alphabet runs A, B, C, D, E, F, G and then starts again at A.

The clef you will use all year is the **treble clef**, sometimes called the G clef. It is a decorated letter G, and the place where its spiral curls shut is not decoration: it closes around the second line up from the bottom, and that is how you know the second line is the note G.

That single fact does all the work. If the second line is G, then the space above it is A, the third line is B, and so on upwards; and going downwards, the first space is F and the bottom line is E.



Figure 1.1 • The treble clef, and the line its spiral closes on.

Put your finger on the spiral and follow it inwards until it stops. The line it stops on is the second from the bottom, and that line is G. Everything else on the stave is counted from there.

◆ WATCH ME PLAY IT

Suppose you are handed a note sitting on the middle line and asked to name it. Do not count from the bottom every time. Start from what the clef gave you.

- ❶ The clef closes on the second line. That line is G.
- ❷ The space above G is the next letter up, A.
- ❸ The next line up is B. That is the middle line, and it is your answer.

Three steps, from a fact you already have. With practice the middle line simply looks like B, in the way a familiar word no longer looks like letters.

● FROM THE WINGS

There are other clefs. The bass clef fixes F, and viola players read a clef that fixes Middle C on whichever line it is placed. A cellist may read all three in one evening. You will use one clef this year, which is enough to be going on with.

CHAPTER 1 • TOPIC 1.3

Middle C, and the little line it sits on

The lesson

Middle C is the note this whole book is built from. It sits roughly in the middle of a piano keyboard, and it is the note where the treble stave and the bass stave meet: too low for one and too high for the other.

Because it is too low for the treble stave, it will not fit on the five lines. It is written **one ledger line below the stave**, with the short line drawn through the middle of the note head. That short line is not an ornament. It is what tells you the note is a full step below the bottom line, rather than sitting in the gap just under it.

In solfa, the system many singers use, Middle C is **do**. You will meet both names in this course: the letter name C for writing and reading, and do for singing.

◆ THROUGH THE NOTE, NOT ABOVE OR BELOW IT

A ledger line is drawn through the note head, sticking out a little on both sides. A note drawn resting on top of a ledger line is a different pitch, and a note drawn floating under the stave with no ledger line at all is not a pitch at all. If you can see white paper between the note and its little line, it is wrong.

CHAPTER 1 • TOPIC 1.4

The semibreve: one sound, four beats

The lesson

Pitch is only half of notation. The other half is **length**: how long each sound lasts. That is shown by the shape of the note rather than its position.

The longest note you will use this year is the **semibreve**, called a whole note in some countries. It is drawn as a hollow oval with no stem at all, and in the time signatures this book uses it lasts **four beats**.

Four beats is a long time. Played properly, a semibreve is a single sound you start once and then leave alone while you count four. Most beginners cut it short at two or three, because holding a sound and doing nothing feels like waiting rather than playing. It is playing. The silence you did not put there is as wrong as a note you did not play.



Figure 1.2 • Middle C as a semibreve, twice.

Two note heads, two bars, eight beats of sound in total. Notice the ledger line through each note, and the counting row underneath: the count restarts at 1 in every bar, which is what the bar line is for.

■ AT THE KEYBOARD

Play Middle C as a semibreve, four times through, counting 1 2 3 4 out loud and evenly. Use the thumb of your right hand. Keep the key held down for the whole count and lift it exactly on the next 1. Record yourself on a phone if you can. Almost everybody discovers they let go on 3.

CHAPTER 1 · TOPIC 1.5

Writing Middle C so another player can read it

The lesson

Reading is one skill and writing is another, and this course tests both. A note you write is an instruction to a stranger. If it is ambiguous, they will play something else, and it will be your fault rather than theirs.

Four things make a written note readable, and they are worth learning as a routine rather than as advice.

- 1 Draw the clef first, always at the far left, before anything else.
- 2 Draw the note head as an oval, not a circle, tilted very slightly, and large enough to touch both sides of its space or to sit clearly across its line.
- 3 Draw the ledger line through Middle C, sticking out a little on each side.
- 4 Leave the note room. A semibreve takes four beats, so it takes four beats of horizontal space. Notation is a picture of time as well as pitch, and cramming a long note into a small gap makes the page lie about the rhythm.

■ YOUR TURN

- ① How many lines does a stave have, and how many spaces?
- ② Which line does the treble clef's spiral close on, and what note is it?
- ③ Name the note on the third line from the bottom. Show your working, starting from the clef.
- ④ Why is Middle C written on a ledger line rather than on the bottom line?
- ⑤ How many beats is a semibreve worth?
- ⑥ Draw a treble clef, then write Middle C as a semibreve twice, leaving each note the horizontal room it deserves.

- ⑦ Your partner has drawn a note under the stave with no ledger line. Write one sentence telling them exactly what is wrong and how to fix it.

■ IN PERFORMANCE

Hold up your written bar at arm's length and ask somebody two rows away to read it. If they hesitate, the problem is your handwriting, not their eyesight. A performer's part has to be readable at a distance, in bad light, by somebody who is nervous. This is the first day of a habit that matters for the rest of the year.

■ GO FURTHER

Find out why the semibreve is called a whole note in the United States and a semibreve in Britain, and what a **breve** was. The names are a fossil: they record a time when notes were written with square heads and the longest note in common use was twice as long as anything you will play this year.

■ THE REHEARSAL

In threes, prepare a thirty second demonstration for the rest of the class called **How to read one note**. One of you draws a stave and a clef on the board, one names a line by counting from the clef, and one plays or sings the note. Rehearse it twice before you show it. You are being marked on whether the three parts fit together, not on whether each part is clever.

■ WHAT YOU CAN NOW DO

- ✓ Name the five lines and four spaces of the treble stave.
- ✓ Say what a clef does and which note the treble clef fixes.
- ✓ Find Middle C on the stave and explain why it needs its own short line.
- ✓ Recognise a semibreve and say how many beats it is worth.
- ✓ Write Middle C as a semibreve clearly enough for a stranger to play it.

■ WORDS FOR THIS CHAPTER

stave, line, space, clef, treble clef, pitch, note head, ledger line, Middle C, solfa, do, semibreve, beat, bar, bar line

How long a note lasts

How the page tells you which notes to hold and which to let go

THE QUESTION THIS CHAPTER ANSWERS

If every note is drawn in roughly the same place, how does the page tell you which ones to hold and which ones to let go?

IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL

- ✓ Recognise and write a minim, and say what it is worth.
- ✓ Recognise and write a crotchet, and say what it is worth.
- ✓ Count a four-beat bar aloud, evenly, without speeding up.
- ✓ Read a line that mixes semibreves, minims and crotchets.
- ✓ Work out how many crotchets fit inside a semibreve, and prove it.

THE TOPICS

- 2.1 The minim: two beats
- 2.2 The crotchet: one beat
- 2.3 Counting a bar out loud
- 2.4 Reading a line of mixed values



LISTEN AND LOOK

musictheory.net, the lessons index. Work through the note-value lessons in order. Stop when you can say how many crotchets fit inside a semibreve without counting.

www.musictheory.net/lessons

Extension only, and not a substitute for the pages. Ask your teacher before you scan.

● BEFORE THE DOWNBEAT

Tap a steady pulse on the desk with one finger, about as fast as a walking pace. Keep it going. Now, without stopping the pulse, say your own name once on every tap, then once on every second tap, then once every fourth tap. Which was hardest, and why? You have just done, badly, the thing this chapter teaches you to do accurately.

CHAPTER 2 · TOPIC 2.1

The minim: two beats

The lesson

A **minim**, called a half note in some countries, lasts **two beats**. It is drawn as a hollow oval, like the semibreve, but with a **stem**: a straight vertical line attached to the side of the note head.

That stem is the whole difference. Hollow with no stem is four beats. Hollow with a stem is two. A single line, half the length.

The stem goes on the right of the note head and points up when the note sits low on the staff, and on the left pointing down when the note sits high. The rule is simple: notes below the middle line have stems up, notes above it have stems down. It is not decoration. Stems pointing in the same direction as their neighbours make a line of music readable at speed; stems that stick out of the stave at both ends make it a puzzle.

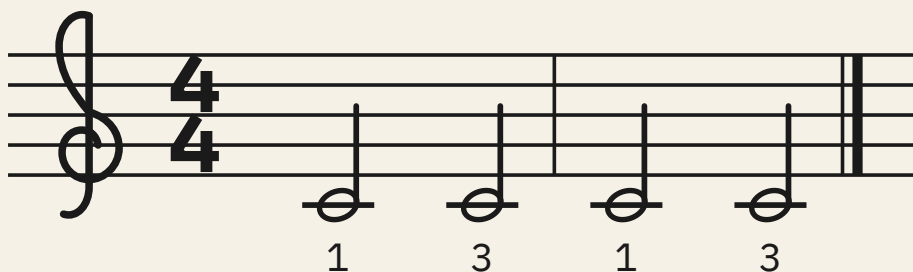


Figure 2.1 • Middle C in minims.

Four note heads, two bars, and a stem on every one. Read the counting row underneath: each minim is held for two counts, so the numbers underneath go 1, 3, 1, 3 rather than 1, 2, 3, 4. The count tells you where in the bar the note starts, not how long it lasts.

◆ THE STEM IS NOT OPTIONAL

A hollow note with no stem is a semibreve, worth four. Forget the stem and you have written a note twice as long as you meant. This is the single commonest writing error in this chapter, and it is invisible to the person who made it, because they know what they meant.

CHAPTER 2 • TOPIC 2.2

The crotchet: one beat

The lesson

A **crotchet**, called a quarter note in some countries, lasts **one beat**. It is drawn exactly like a minim, with a stem, except that the note head is **filled in solid**.

So the three notes you now know work like this, and the pattern is worth saying out loud until it is automatic. Hollow, no stem: four. Hollow, stem: two. Filled, stem: one. Each step halves the length, and each step adds one thing to the drawing.

The crotchet is the note the beat is usually counted in. When you tap your foot to music, you are almost always tapping crotchets.

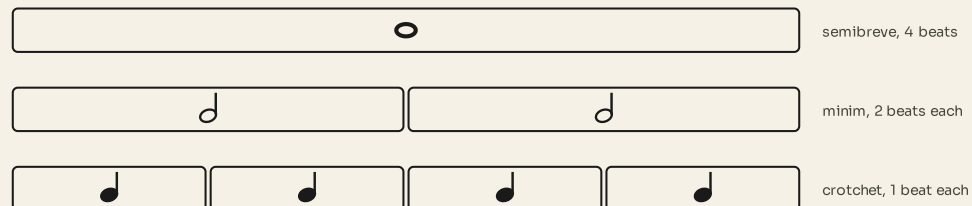


Figure 2.2 • One semibreve, two minims, four crotchets, drawn to the same total length.

Each row lasts exactly as long as the row above it. This is the picture to remember: it is why a semibreve is worth four crotchets, rather than a fact you have to take on trust.



Figure 2.3 • Middle C in crotchets.

Eight notes, two bars, and the count runs straight through 1 2 3 4 in each bar, because every note is worth exactly one beat.

CHAPTER 2 • TOPIC 2.3

Counting a bar out loud

The lesson

A **bar** is a group of beats, marked off by vertical **bar lines** through the stave. In this chapter every bar holds four beats, so every bar is counted 1 2 3 4 and then starts again at 1.

Counting out loud is not a beginner's crutch that you grow out of. Professional players count. It is the only way to know, at the moment you play a note, where in the bar you are, and it is the only way two players can find out which of them is wrong.

Three rules make counting work, and all three are broken constantly.

- ❶ **Count evenly.** Most people speed up on 3 and 4. Tap a foot, or use a metronome, so the count is measured by something outside your own impatience.
- ❷ **Count out loud, not in your head.** In your head, a count bends to fit whatever your fingers did. Out loud, it does not.
- ❸ **Keep counting through long notes.** A semibreve is 1 2 3 4 with sound on all four. Stopping the count while the note rings is how a four-beat note becomes a two-beat note.

◆ WATCH ME PLAY IT

Take the first bar of the mixed line in topic 2.4: a minim, then two crotchets.

- ❶ Say the whole bar before playing it: 1 2 3 4, evenly.
- ❷ Work out where each note starts. The minim starts on 1 and is held through 2. The first crotchet starts on 3. The second starts on 4.
- ❸ Now say the count and play only on 1, 3 and 4, holding the first sound through the 2.
- ❹ Play it four times without stopping between repeats. If you cannot get from the end of the bar back to the start without a gap, the bar is not learned.

CHAPTER 2 · TOPIC 2.4

Reading a line of mixed values

The lesson

Real music mixes note values, and the moment it does, two things become possible: a tune can have a rhythm, and a reader can get lost.

The way not to get lost is to read the bar before playing it. Look at the bar, name the values, add them up, and check the total is four. If it is not four, either you have misread a note or the bar is wrong. Both happen, and you should be able to tell the difference.

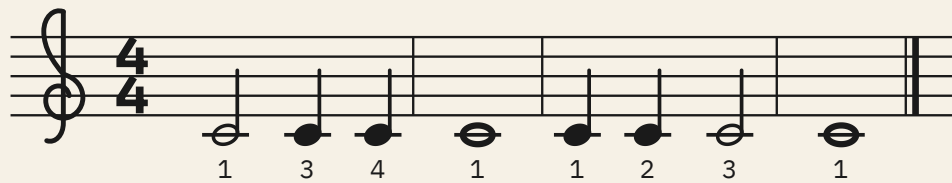


Figure 2.4 • A line of mixed values.

Four bars, and every one adds up to four beats by a different route. Check the third bar for yourself: crotchet, crotchet, minim, which is 1 plus 1 plus 2.

● LISTEN AGAIN

Close the book. Your teacher, or a partner, claps one of the four bars above. Say which one it was. Then swap.

Doing this by ear after doing it by eye is not revision, it is a different skill. Reading tells you what to expect; listening tells you what actually happened. A musician needs both, and most people are much weaker at the second one than they think.

● ON YOUR FEET

Stand in a circle. The teacher calls a note value and everybody moves for its length: a crotchet is one step, a minim is a step and a hold, a semibreve is a step and three counts of stillness. The stillness is the point. Most of the class will fidget through the semibreve, and that fidget is exactly what their playing does to a long note.

■ AT THE KEYBOARD

Play the mixed line above four times through, counting out loud, at a speed slow enough that you never stop. Slow and unbroken beats fast and interrupted, every time. If you can play it at a walking pace without a single gap, it is learned; if you can play it fast with three stumbles, it is not.

■ YOUR TURN

- 1 How many beats is a minim worth? And a crotchet?
- 2 What is the only difference in drawing between a minim and a crotchet?
- 3 How many crotchets are worth the same as one semibreve? Draw the working.
- 4 A pupil writes a bar of four beats as: minim, minim, crotchet. What is wrong, and what are the two different ways of fixing it?

- 5 Write one bar of four beats using exactly three notes. There is more than one right answer.

- 6 Write four bars of four beats using only minims and crotchets, and no two bars the same.

● FROM THE WINGS

The word crotchet comes from the French *crochet*, a little hook, because the note used to be drawn with a hook on its stem. The hook migrated to a shorter note centuries ago and the name stayed behind on the wrong note. Musical vocabulary is full of fossils like this.

■ IN PERFORMANCE

Two of you play the mixed line together, from one copy, standing up. Do not count out loud this time: agree the tempo first, breathe in together, and start on that breath. The shared breath before the first note is how every ensemble on earth starts together, from a string quartet to a rock band.

GO FURTHER

Find out what a **quaver** is and how it is drawn, then work out how many quavers fit in a bar of four beats. You will not need them until next year, but the pattern of halving is now obvious enough that you can predict the answer before you look it up.

THE REHEARSAL

In fours, compose eight bars of rhythm on Middle C using only the three values you know. Write it out neatly enough for another group to read. Swap with another group and perform theirs, not your own. You are being marked on whether the other group could play what you wrote, which is the only real test of notation.

WHAT YOU CAN NOW DO

- ✓ Recognise, name and write a minim, and say what it is worth.
- ✓ Recognise, name and write a crotchet, and say what it is worth.
- ✓ Count a four-beat bar aloud, evenly, without speeding up.
- ✓ Read a line that mixes semibreves, minims and crotchets.
- ✓ Check that a bar adds up, and say what is wrong when it does not.

WORDS FOR THIS CHAPTER

minim, crotchet, stem, note head, filled, hollow, bar, bar line, beat, pulse, tempo, metronome, value

Middle C at the keyboard

Eighty-eight keys that all look alike, and the pattern that sorts them

THE QUESTION THIS CHAPTER ANSWERS

There are eighty-eight keys and they all look alike from a distance, so how do you find the right one without counting from the end every time?

IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL

- ✓ Describe the pattern of two and three black keys.
- ✓ Find Middle C on any keyboard in under a second.
- ✓ Sit and hold your right hand in a correct, relaxed position.
- ✓ Use the fingering numbers 1 to 5 and say which finger is which.
- ✓ Play eight bars at Middle C in time, counting aloud.

THE TOPICS

- 3.1 The pattern of the keys
- 3.2 Finding Middle C every time
- 3.3 The right hand: shape, weight and fingering
- 3.4 Your first eight bars



LISTEN AND LOOK

musictheory.net, Keyboard Note Identification. The machine names a note and you find the key. Do twenty. If Middle C still takes you more than a second, go back to topic 3.1.

www.musictheory.net/exercises/keyboard

Extension only, and not a substitute for the pages. Ask your teacher before you scan.

● BEFORE THE DOWNBEAT

Look at a piano keyboard, or a picture of one, for ten seconds. Then look away and describe the pattern of the black keys to a partner accurately enough that they could draw it. Almost nobody manages this first time, and the reason is that most people have looked at a keyboard hundreds of times without ever once seeing it.

CHAPTER 3 · TOPIC 3.1

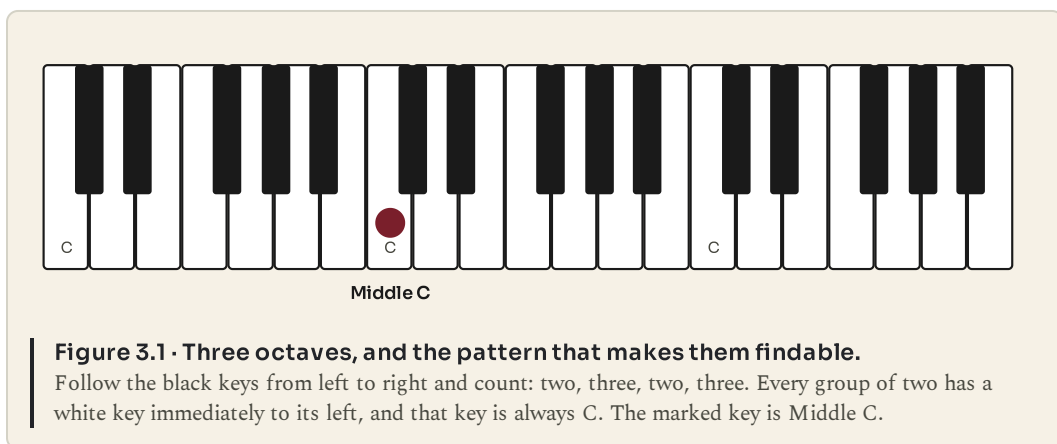
The pattern of the keys

The lesson

A keyboard looks, at a glance, like a long row of identical white keys. It is not. Sitting behind them is a pattern that repeats all the way up, and once you can see it you can never unsee it.

The black keys are grouped in **twos and threes**, alternating: two, three, two, three, all the way from one end to the other. That is the whole pattern, and it is what makes the keyboard navigable. Without it, finding a note would mean counting from the end of the instrument every single time.

Each repetition of the pattern covers seven white keys, and those seven white keys are the seven letters of the musical alphabet: C, D, E, F, G, A, B. Then it starts again at C. The distance from one C to the next is called an **octave**, from the Latin for eight, because you count eight white keys including both ends.



CHAPTER 3 · TOPIC 3.2

Finding Middle C every time

The lesson

Here is the rule, and it is the most useful single sentence in this chapter: **C is the white key immediately to the left of any group of two black keys.**

That is true of every C on the instrument. It works on a full-size piano, on a small classroom keyboard, on a church organ and on a phone application. You never count from the end. You find a group of two black keys, and you drop to the white key on their left.

Middle C is then the C nearest the middle of the instrument. On a full-size piano it is the one roughly in line with the manufacturer's name, and roughly in front of your breastbone when you are sitting properly.

◆ DO NOT COUNT FROM THE BOTTOM

Beginners find Middle C by counting keys from the left-hand end. It works, it takes four seconds, and it stops working the moment you sit at a different instrument or the moment you are nervous. Use the two-black-key rule from the first day and you will never lose the note.

● ON YOUR FEET

Work in pairs at a keyboard, or on a keyboard drawn on paper. One of you closes their eyes; the other says "find Middle C". Open, find, close. Repeat ten times, timing each other. Get it under a second. This is a physical habit, not a piece of knowledge, and habits are built by repetition rather than by understanding.

CHAPTER 3 · TOPIC 3.3

The right hand: shape, weight and fingering

The lesson

How you hold your hand decides what you will be able to play in three years, so it is worth ten minutes now.

The shape. Allow your arm to hang loose by your side and look at your hand. The fingers curve naturally, and the palm is slightly domed. That is the shape you want at the keyboard: lift the arm without changing it. Flat fingers and a collapsed palm are the two faults to watch for, and both come from trying too hard rather than from not trying.

The weight. The sound comes from the weight of a relaxed arm dropping into the key, not from pushing with the finger. Press a key slowly and hold it: you should feel the weight resting, not muscles straining. A hand that aches after ten minutes is a hand that is working instead of resting.

The fingering. Every pianist in the world numbers the fingers the same way, and the numbers are printed in music, so they are worth learning immediately:

- 1 thumb
- 2 index finger
- 3 middle finger
- 4 ring finger
- 5 little finger

Both hands use the same numbers, counting outwards from the thumb. That means the two hands mirror each other, which is confusing for about a week and then never again.

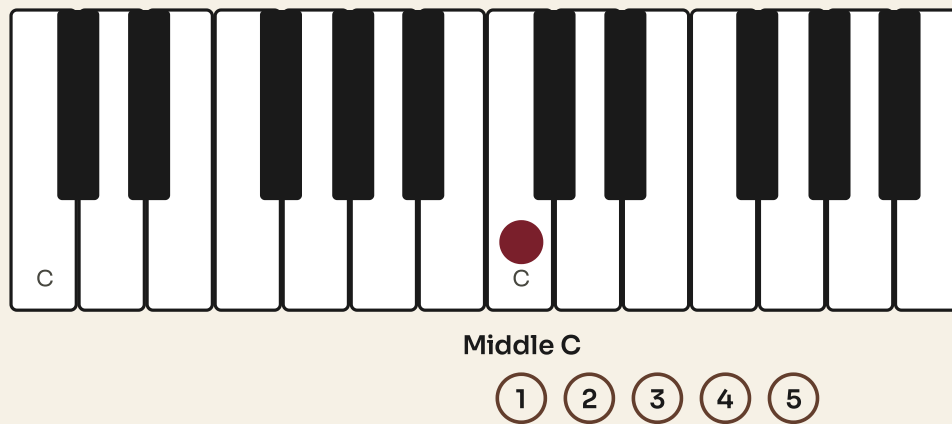


Figure 3.2 • The right hand at Middle C, with the five fingering numbers.

Thumb on Middle C, then one finger to each of the next four white keys. This is called five finger position, and almost everything in this book is played from it.

■ AT THE KEYBOARD

Sit down properly before you play a note. Bench far enough back that your forearms are roughly level with the keys. Feet flat on the floor. Sit forward on the bench rather than slumped against the back of it. Shoulders down.

Now put the thumb of your right hand on Middle C and let the other four fingers rest, one on each of the next four white keys, without pressing. Play 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, then 5, 4, 3, 2, 1, slowly, one note per beat, counting aloud. Listen for whether every note is the same loudness. It will not be. The fourth finger is weak in everybody, for anatomical reasons, and evening it out is a job for the whole year rather than for today.

CHAPTER 3 • TOPIC 3.4

Your first eight bars

The lesson

You now have everything you need to play a real line of music: a note you can find, three note values you can read, a bar you can count and a hand position you can hold.

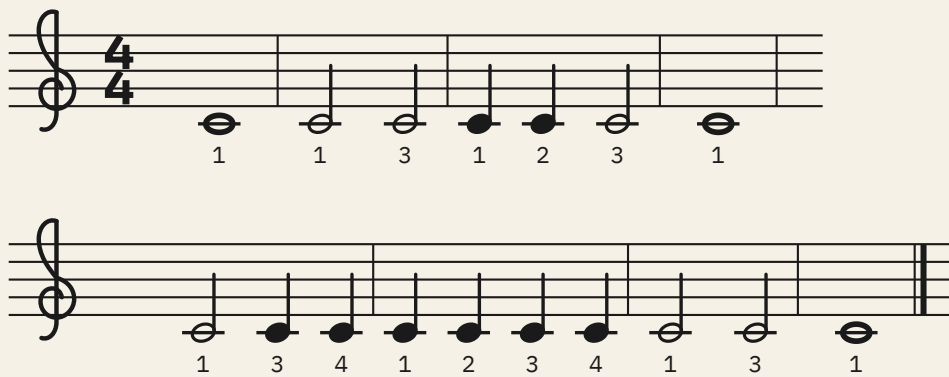


Figure 3.3 · Your first eight bars.

All on Middle C, all with the right thumb, in four four. Read each bar before you play it and check it adds up to four.

Practise it in four steps, in this order, and do not skip a step because the previous one felt easy.

- ❶ Say the counting for all eight bars, evenly, without the instrument.
- ❷ Clap the rhythm while saying the counting.
- ❸ Play it very slowly, still counting out loud, at a speed where you never have to stop.
- ❹ Play it four times without stopping, including the join from bar eight back to bar one.

■ YOUR TURN

- ➊ Which white key is always immediately to the left of a group of two black keys?
 - ➋ How many white keys are there in one octave, counting both Cs?
 - ➌ Which finger is number 4 on your right hand?
 - ➍ Describe, in one sentence, where the sound should come from when you play a key.
-
- ➎ Bar 3 of the eight bars above contains crotchet, crotchet, minim. Show that it adds up to four beats.
 - ➏ Practise the eight bars for four days, five minutes a day, and write down each day what you could do at the end of the session that you could not do at the start.

■ IN PERFORMANCE

Play your eight bars for one other person, standing behind you where you cannot see them. Before you start, wait. Put your hand in position, breathe once, and only then play. That two-second wait feels enormous when you are doing it and is invisible to the audience, and learning to take it is most of what separates a performance from a demonstration.

● FROM THE WINGS

The full-size piano keyboard has 88 keys, spanning a little over seven octaves, and that size was settled by the firm of Steinway in the 1880s. Before then keyboards varied, which is why some earlier music simply cannot be played as written on the instrument the composer owned.

GO FURTHER

Find middle C on three different instruments, or three different pictures of instruments, and notice that it is in a different physical place each time while being the same note. Then find out why a guitar's music is written an octave higher than it sounds.

THE REHEARSAL

In pairs, prepare a one minute teaching demonstration called **Finding Middle C in under a second**, aimed at a Year 7 pupil who has never touched a keyboard. One of you explains, the other demonstrates. Rehearse it twice. You will be marked on whether a Year 7 pupil could actually do it afterwards, which is a higher bar than whether your explanation was correct.

WHAT YOU CAN NOW DO

- ✓ Describe the pattern of two and three black keys.
- ✓ Find Middle C on any keyboard, using the pattern rather than by counting.
- ✓ Sit and hold your right hand in a correct, relaxed position.
- ✓ Use the fingering numbers 1 to 5 and say which finger is which.
- ✓ Play eight bars at Middle C in time, counting aloud.

WORDS FOR THIS CHAPTER

keyboard, white key, black key, octave, musical alphabet, Middle C, five finger position, fingering, thumb, weight, posture, bench

Checkpoint one

The first checkpoint, and how to read what it tells you

THE QUESTION THIS CHAPTER ANSWERS

Can you now read, write and play what you have been taught, on a day when nobody is helping you?

IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL

- ✓ Say exactly what checkpoint one tests and how long each part takes.
- ✓ Answer written questions on the stave, the clef and the note values.
- ✓ Play a prepared passage and a passage you have not seen.
- ✓ Identify note values by ear.
- ✓ Read your own result and name the one thing to practise next.

THE TOPICS

- 4.1 What checkpoint one asks
- 4.2 The written paper
- 4.3 The playing and listening test
- 4.4 Reading your own result



LISTEN AND LOOK

musictheory.net, Note Identification. The same test checkpoint one sets you, as often as you want it, with the answer straight away. Use it before the checkpoint, not after.

www.musictheory.net/exercises/note

Extension only, and not a substitute for the pages. Ask your teacher before you scan.

● BEFORE THE DOWNBEAT

Before you read any further, write down what you think you will be tested on. Then read this chapter and compare. If there is something in the chapter that was not on your list, that is the thing to practise. If there is something on your list that is not in the chapter, you can stop worrying about it.

CHAPTER 4 · TOPIC 4.1

What checkpoint one asks

The lesson

Checkpoint one takes a triple lesson, and it is in three parts of equal length: a written paper, a playing test and a listening test. Nothing in it is a surprise. Everything it asks was taught in chapters 1 to 3 and practised in a **Your turn** panel.

The point of a checkpoint is not to sort the class into good and bad. It is to find out, while there is still most of a year left, which of five specific things you cannot yet do, so that you can be taught them again. A checkpoint you did badly on, and then acted on, is more useful than one you passed and forgot.

PART	WHAT IT ASKS	TAUGHT IN
Written	The stave, the clef, naming notes, Middle C, note values	Chapters 1 and 2
Playing	Posture, hand position, eight bars at Middle C, counting aloud	Chapter 3
Listening	Telling note values apart by ear	Chapters 1 and 2

Table 4.1 • What checkpoint one covers, and where it was taught.

Use the right-hand column: if you are unsure of a row, you know exactly which pages to go back to.

CHAPTER 4 • TOPIC 4.2

The written paper

The lesson

The written paper lasts forty-five minutes and is done without an instrument. It asks you to name things, to draw things and to check things.

Naming means: how many lines has a stave, which line does the treble clef fix, what note is on the third line, how many beats is a minim worth.

Drawing means: write a treble clef, write Middle C as a semibreve, write a bar of four beats using three notes. Drawing is marked on whether another player could read it, not on whether it is pretty.

Checking means: here is a bar that does not add up, say what is wrong with it. This is the part most people lose marks on, because it is the only part that cannot be answered by remembering. You have to add up.

◆ READ THE BAR BEFORE YOU ANSWER

In a checking question, count the beats first and write the total in the margin. Half the marks lost on this section are lost by pupils who saw a note they recognised and answered before they had added anything up.

CHAPTER 4 · TOPIC 4.3

The playing and listening test

The lesson

The playing test is short and you play it one at a time, to your teacher, with the rest of the class out of the room or working silently. You will be asked to:

- ① sit down and put your right hand in position, without being told how;
- ② find Middle C;
- ③ play the eight bars from topic 3.4, counting out loud;
- ④ play a two-bar rhythm you have not seen before, after thirty seconds to look at it.

The marks are not mostly for the notes. They are for whether the counting is steady, whether the hand stayed relaxed, and whether you kept going when something went wrong. A performance with one wrong note and no hesitation scores higher than a performance with all the right notes and three stops, because the first one is music and the second one is practice.

The listening test asks you to hear a note or a short pattern and say what the values were. It is done as a class, on paper.

● ON YOUR FEET

Practise the playing test as a performance rather than as a piece. Set up a chair at the front of the room. One at a time, walk to it, sit, take your time, play, and walk back. Do it three times each. By the third time the walk is boring, and boring is exactly what you want it to be on the day.

CHAPTER 4 · TOPIC 4.4

Reading your own result

The lesson

You will get back three marks and a sentence. The three marks are not the useful part. The useful part is working out which of the five things below you cannot yet do, because that is what the next term is built on.

■ YOUR TURN

Tick honestly. This is for you, not for a mark.

- 1 I can name any line or space on the treble stave, starting from the clef.
.....
- 2 I can find Middle C on a keyboard in under a second, without counting from the end.
.....
- 3 I can write a semibreve, a minim and a crotchet so that somebody else could read them.
.....
- 4 I can count a four-beat bar out loud, evenly, while playing.
.....
- 5 I can check whether a bar adds up, and say what is wrong when it does not.
.....

Now write one sentence naming the single thing you will practise first, and how often.

■ IN PERFORMANCE

Nerves are not a sign that something is wrong. A faster heartbeat and shallow breathing are your body preparing to do something that matters, and every performer alive has them. What you can change is the breathing: two slow breaths, out for longer than in, before you sit down. It works because it is physiology rather than confidence.

● FROM THE WINGS

Professional orchestral auditions are usually played behind a screen, so the panel hears the playing and nothing else. The practice spread after orchestras that adopted it began hiring noticeably differently from those that did not. It is a useful reminder that what an audience thinks it is judging and what it is actually judging are not always the same.

■ GO FURTHER

Write the checkpoint you would set, for the same three chapters, if you were the teacher. Include one question you think would be unfair, and say why. Working out what makes a question unfair is a fast way of understanding what the fair ones are testing.

■ THE REHEARSAL

In pairs, run each other's playing test the day before the real one. Sit where the teacher will sit. Mark it out of ten for steadiness of counting, and say one thing that would raise the mark. Being the examiner for ten minutes teaches you more about what is being looked for than any amount of being examined.

■ WHAT YOU CAN NOW DO

- ✓ Say exactly what checkpoint one tests and how long each part takes.
- ✓ Answer written questions on the stave, the clef and the note values.
- ✓ Play a prepared passage and a passage you have not seen.
- ✓ Identify note values by ear.
- ✓ Read your own result and name the one thing to practise next.

■ WORDS FOR THIS CHAPTER

checkpoint, written paper, playing test, listening test, sight-reading, steady, tempo, self-assessment, nerves

PART TWO

Beat, time and the first songs

A note on a page is not yet music. Music happens when notes are put in time, and time in music is not a vague sense of speed: it is a pulse, cut into bars, with one beat in each bar stronger than the rest. These four chapters give you that pulse, the two numbers that describe it, three pieces to play, a dance to learn, and the first time you stand up in front of an audience.

Sitting down to play

Why the same passage is easy at one bench height and impossible at another

THE QUESTION THIS CHAPTER ANSWERS

Why does the same passage feel easy at one bench height and impossible at another?

IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL

- ✓ Set the bench to the right height and check it every time you sit down.
- ✓ Describe correct posture, wrist height and hand shape.
- ✓ Follow a practice routine of short, frequent sessions.
- ✓ Keep a practice record and say honestly what you did.
- ✓ Use a practice application without letting it replace listening.

THE TOPICS

- 5.1 Bench height, posture and wrists
- 5.2 A practice routine that actually works
- 5.3 Practising with Simply Piano



LISTEN AND LOOK

Philharmonia Orchestra, Resources. A professional orchestra's own teaching material. Find one player talking about how they practise and compare it with topic 5.2.

philharmonia.co.uk/resources/

Extension only, and not a substitute for the pages. Ask your teacher before you scan.

● BEFORE THE DOWNBEAT

Think of something you can do without thinking: tying a lace, riding a bicycle. How long did it take, and what did the practice actually look like? Two sentences. Most people find their bicycle practice looked nothing like their music practice, and this chapter is about why that matters.

CHAPTER 5 · TOPIC 5.1

Bench height, posture and wrists

The lesson

Almost every difficulty a beginner has at a keyboard in the first year is caused by the bench, and almost nobody checks the bench.

Height. Sitting correctly, your forearms run roughly level with the keys and your elbows sit level with or slightly above your wrists. Too low and you play with dropped wrists and reaching fingers, which is exhausting. Too high and you press down from the shoulders, which is worse.

Distance. Far enough back that your arms are not folded against your body, close enough that you are not stretching. Sit on the front half of the bench, feet flat on the floor, back straight but not rigid.

Wrists. The wrist stays roughly level and stays loose. A wrist locked in one position for a whole piece is the first thing to hurt.

◆ PAIN IS A STOP SIGN

If your hand, wrist, forearm or shoulder aches while you play, stop and tell your teacher. It is not toughness, it is a fault in how you are sitting or how hard you are pressing. It is cheap to correct now and expensive to correct in five years.

CHAPTER 5 · TOPIC 5.2

A practice routine that actually works

The lesson

The findings on how skills are learned are uncomfortable, because they are the opposite of what feels productive.

Short and often beats long and rare. Five sessions of ten minutes across a week teaches more than one session of an hour. The brain consolidates between sessions, so the gaps are part of the practice.

Slow beats fast. Playing something fast and wrong teaches your hands to play it wrong, and unlearning takes longer than learning.

Small beats whole. If two bars are the problem, practise those two bars. Starting from the beginning every time means you practise the opening forty times and the difficult bar four times.

Naming beats repeating. Before you repeat a passage, say out loud what went wrong. "My fourth finger was late" is practice. "Again" is not.

MINUTES	WHAT YOU DO	WHY
2	Five fingers up and down, slowly	The hand is woken before it is used
4	The two hardest bars, alone, slowly	The unlearned part gets the most time
3	The piece from the start, without stopping	Joining is a separate skill from playing
1	Write down what to fix tomorrow	Tomorrow's session begins before it starts

Table 5.1 · What ten minutes should contain.

Not a plan for your best day: a plan for an ordinary Tuesday when you do not feel like it.

CHAPTER 5 · TOPIC 5.3

Practising with Simply Piano

The lesson

A book can tell you what to play. It cannot tell you whether you played it. That is the one thing a practice application does well: it listens and says, immediately, that the third note was wrong. Immediate feedback is genuinely valuable, and it is why this course uses **Simply Piano** between lessons.

Be clear about what it is not good at, because a pupil who believes an application is a teacher will stop improving. It cannot see your wrist. It does not know you have started gripping. It rewards accuracy over sound, and it cannot tell you that a passage was correct and lifeless. Those are the things your teacher is for.



PRACTISE BETWEEN LESSONS

Simply Piano. The practice application this course uses. It listens to your playing and tells you which note was wrong, which is the one thing a book cannot do. Free to start; the full course is paid, so check with your teacher or an adult at home before signing up for anything.

www.hellosimply.com/simply-piano

Extension only, and not a substitute for the pages. Ask your teacher before you scan.

■ AT THE KEYBOARD

Keep the routine above for seven days: ten minutes, five days, in that order. Write down each day what you fixed. Bring the list to the next lesson.

● ON YOUR FEET

Shake out your hands, arms and shoulders for thirty seconds before you sit down. Then sit and notice where your shoulders are. Most people find they had been holding them somewhere near their ears. Tension you cannot feel is still tension, and this is how you find it.

■ YOUR TURN

- ① Give two ways of telling that a bench is at the wrong height.
- ② Why is five sessions of ten minutes better than one of fifty?
- ③ What should you do before repeating a passage that went wrong?
- ④ Name one thing an application does better than a book, and one it cannot do.

- ⑤ Plan your own ten minutes for a piece you are actually working on.

■ IN PERFORMANCE

Practise standing up and sitting down. It sounds absurd until the first concert, when you find that walking to an instrument and settling in front of an audience are things you have never rehearsed. They take thirty seconds and they are the first thing anybody sees.

■ WHAT YOU CAN NOW DO

- ✓ Set the bench to the right height and check it every time you sit down.
- ✓ Describe correct posture, wrist height and hand shape.
- ✓ Follow a practice routine of short, frequent sessions.
- ✓ Keep a practice record and say honestly what you did.
- ✓ Use a practice application without letting it replace listening.

■ WORDS FOR THIS CHAPTER

bench, posture, wrist, tension, practice routine, feedback, consolidation, tempo, accuracy

The first songs, and your first dance

Two songs, and what changes the moment you have to move to them

THE QUESTION THIS CHAPTER ANSWERS

What changes about a song the moment you have to move to it?

IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL

- ✓ Describe what makes The Train sound like a train.
- ✓ Sing and play The Train in time, counting aloud.
- ✓ Find and walk the pulse of The Seabees.
- ✓ Learn an eight-count dance figure and repeat it accurately.
- ✓ Sing and move at the same time without one wrecking the other.

THE TOPICS

- 6.1 Listening to The Train
- 6.2 Singing and playing The Train
- 6.3 The Seabees: a pulse you can walk to
- 6.4 The dance: eight counts, four figures



LISTEN AND LOOK

SFS Kids, San Francisco Symphony. Build a rhythm and hear it played back. Try to make something that sounds like a train before you look at what this chapter did.

www.sfskids.org/

Extension only, and not a substitute for the pages. Ask your teacher before you scan.

● BEFORE THE DOWNBEAT

Without using the words "fast" or "loud", describe the sound of a train to somebody who has never heard one. Two sentences. Keep what you wrote: at the end of this chapter you will check whether the piece you have learned does any of the things you described.

CHAPTER 6 · TOPIC 6.1

Listening to The Train

The lesson

The Train is the first song of this course, and it is chosen because it does something obvious. Listen for three things before you play a note.

The pulse. Completely regular. You could walk to it, and a train is the easiest thing in the world to walk to.

The repetition. The same short pattern returns, and returns again. A train is not a tune that develops; it is a tune that keeps going.

The shape. The melody rises and comes home. Something sets off, goes somewhere and returns, which is what a journey is.

None of those three is about the notes being difficult. A piece can be very simple and still be unmistakably about something.

CHAPTER 6 • TOPIC 6.2

Singing and playing The Train

The lesson

Sing it before you play it. That is a rule for the whole year. If you cannot sing a phrase you do not yet know how it goes, and your fingers will be guessing. Singing also fixes rhythm faster than playing does, because your voice is not solving a fingering problem at the same time.



Figure 6.1 • The Train.

Two four throughout, in the note values you already know. The words sit under the counting, so you can see which syllable lands on which beat.

Play it in five finger position, right hand, thumb on Middle C. Every note falls under a finger that is already there. Count out loud: in two four the count is 1 2, 1 2, and the strong beat is the 1.

◆ THE LAST NOTE IS NOT A FULL STOP

Almost everybody rushes the last bar to get it over with. The final minim is worth two beats and needs both of them. A piece that ends early sounds like somebody sitting down before the applause.

CHAPTER 6 · TOPIC 6.3

The Seabees: a pulse you can walk to

The lesson

The Seabees does the same job as **The Train** and asks one more thing of you: you have to move while you sing it.



Figure 6.2 · The Seabees.

Notice how much of it moves by step rather than by leap. A tune that moves by step is a tune a group can sing together on the first attempt, which is exactly what a walking song needs to be.

● LISTEN AGAIN

Your teacher plays one of the two pieces with a single thing deliberately wrong: a wrong note, a rushed bar, or a shortened last note. Say which of the three, and then say which bar. Anybody can hear that something was wrong. A musician can point at it.

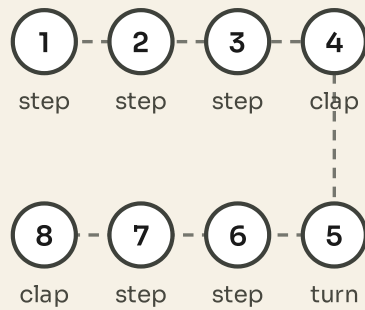
CHAPTER 6 · TOPIC 6.4

The dance: eight counts, four figures

The lesson

A dance is learned in **phrases of eight counts**, because that is how music is built and because eight is about as much as anybody can hold at once.

The figure below is four moves of two counts each. Learn it in halves: counts 1 to 4 first, then 5 to 8, then join them. Joining is a separate job, exactly as it is at the keyboard.



One eight-count phrase, danced twice through.

Figure 6.3 · One eight-count phrase.

The numbers are counts, not steps: on count 4 you clap without moving your feet, and on count 5 you turn. Follow the dotted line and you have the whole figure.

Three rules make a group dance look like a group rather than eight people doing the same thing near each other. **Keep your spacing:** check the distance to the person beside you on every count 1. **Start on the count, not after it:** the first move happens on 1, which means you must be ready before 1. **Look up:** a dancer watching their own feet has stopped performing.

● **ON YOUR FEET**

Do the figure four times through without music, counting aloud. Then four times with somebody playing The Seabees. Then four times singing it yourselves while you dance. Almost everybody loses the tune at that third stage, and the reason is worth naming: your voice and your feet are competing for the same counting, and the counting has to become automatic before it can be shared.

■ YOUR TURN

- ① Name three things in The Train that make it sound like a train.
 - ② Why does this book ask you to sing a piece before you play it?
 - ③ In two four, which beat is the strong one?
 - ④ What are the three rules that make a group dance look like a group?
-
- ⑤ Write two bars of your own, in two four, on Middle C, that would sound like a train slowing down, and say in one sentence why they would.

■ IN PERFORMANCE

Announce the piece before you play it: title, and one thing to listen for, in a single sentence. Announcing is performed with the voice rather than the instrument, and no audience is on your side until somebody has spoken to them once.

● FROM THE WINGS

Trains have been a subject for composers since almost the moment they existed. Honegger's *Pacific 231*, from 1923, is an orchestral piece imitating a steam locomotive accelerating with a heavy load, and it is doing exactly what this chapter's opening question asked of you.

■ WHAT YOU CAN NOW DO

- ✓ Describe what makes The Train sound like a train.
- ✓ Sing and play The Train in time, counting aloud.
- ✓ Find and walk the pulse of The Seabees.
- ✓ Learn an eight-count dance figure and repeat it accurately.
- ✓ Sing and move at the same time without one wrecking the other.

■ WORDS FOR THIS CHAPTER

pulse, repetition, melodic shape, step, leap, phrase, eight-count, spacing, two four, strong beat, announcing a piece

Two beats, three beats, and March of the Gnomes

The two numbers at the start of the music, and what they order you to do

THE QUESTION THIS CHAPTER ANSWERS

What are those two numbers at the start of the music actually telling you to do?

IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL

- ✓ Explain what the top and bottom numbers of a time signature mean.
- ✓ Describe the strong and weak pattern of two four and of three four.
- ✓ Play March of the Gnomes, and say what gives a march its character.
- ✓ Bar a given rhythm correctly in two four and in three four.
- ✓ Hear a piece and say whether it is in two or in three.

THE TOPICS

- 7.1 What a time signature tells you
- 7.2 Two four: strong, weak
- 7.3 March of the Gnomes, and character in music
- 7.4 Three four: strong, weak, weak
- 7.5 Telling two from three by ear



LISTEN AND LOOK

BBC Bitesize, KS3 Music. The same subject taught a different way. Find its pages on metre and check them against your own answer to topic 8.1.

www.bbc.co.uk/bitesize/subjects/zmsvr82

Extension only, and not a substitute for the pages. Ask your teacher before you scan.

● BEFORE THE DOWNBEAT

Clap a steady pulse. Now, without changing the speed, make every third clap louder. Then start again and make every second clap louder. The pulse did not change either time, and yet the music did. What changed?

CHAPTER 7 · TOPIC 7.1

What a time signature tells you

The lesson

At the start of a piece, just after the clef, sit two numbers, one above the other. They are the **time signature**, and they answer two questions.

The **top number** says how many beats are in each bar. The **bottom number** says which kind of note gets one beat. In everything you play this year the bottom number is 4, which means a crotchet gets the beat.

So 2/4 is two crotchet beats in a bar. 3/4 is three. 4/4 is four.

◆ IT IS NOT A FRACTION

Two four is not "two quarters" and there is no line between the numbers. Writing it as a fraction is the commonest error in a written paper, and it suggests you think the two numbers are being divided, which would mean something else entirely.

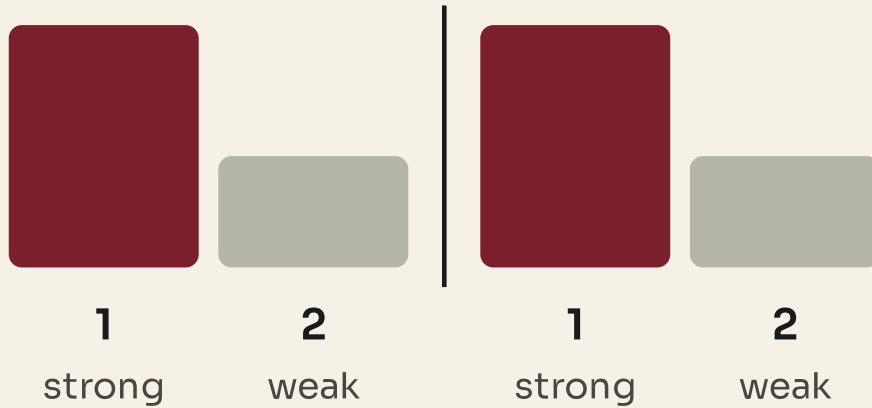
CHAPTER 7 · TOPIC 7.2

Two four: strong, weak

The lesson

Knowing how many beats are in a bar is only half of it. The other half is that they are not equal. The **first beat of every bar is stronger** than the rest, and that is what you actually hear when you recognise a metre.

In two four the pattern is **strong, weak, strong, weak**. It is the pattern of walking, which is why almost every marching piece ever written is in two.



2/4: 2 beats in every bar, and a crotchet gets one of the

Figure 7.1 • Two four, drawn as height.

Two bars, so you can see the pattern repeat. The tall crimson bar is the strong beat, and it lands on 1 every time. Colour means the same thing here as everywhere else in this book: crimson is the beat you lean on.

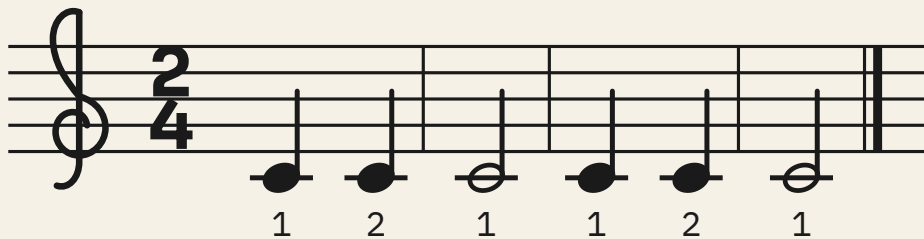


Figure 7.2 • Two four on the staff.

Four bars at Middle C. Say the count aloud with the 1 slightly stronger, and you have the whole idea.

CHAPTER 7 • TOPIC 7.3

March of the Gnomes, and character in music

The lesson

March of the Gnomes is in two four, and it is the first piece in this course that is about a character rather than about a thing.

A march makes people move together, so it needs a strong, plain, regular beat. A march about **gnomes** needs something more: it has to sound small, low and slightly comic. Listen for how it does that. The tune moves in short steps rather than long leaps, it keeps returning to where it started, and it never hurries. Something small, walking, unbothered.



Figure 7.3 • March of the Gnomes, in two four.

Eight bars. Look at how narrow the tune is: nothing goes far from where it began, and that narrowness is most of what makes it sound like a small creature rather than a large one.

● ON YOUR FEET

Walk the march as a group, one step per beat, leaning very slightly into every

- 1 Then walk it as gnomes: knees bent, small steps, same tempo exactly. The

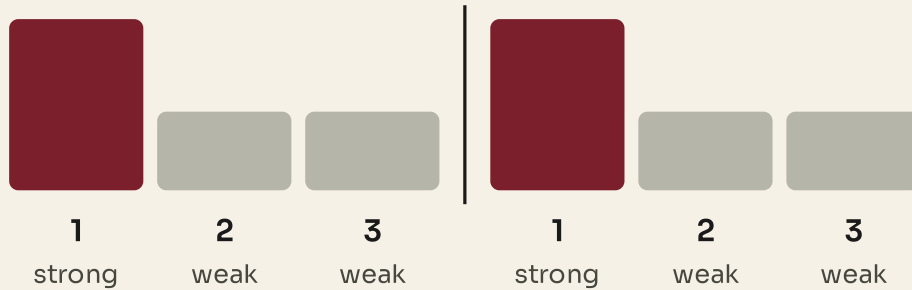
tempo must not change, and it will want to. Learning to change the character without changing the speed is the whole exercise.

CHAPTER 7 • TOPIC 7.4

Three four: strong, weak, weak

The lesson

In **three four** there are three crotchet beats in a bar, and the pattern is **strong, weak, weak**. It does not feel like walking, because people do not walk in threes. It feels like turning, which is why waltzes are in three.



3/4: 3 beats in every bar, and a crotchet gets one of them.

Figure 7.4 • Three four, drawn as height.

One tall beat and two short ones, twice. Compare it with the two four map above and notice that the difference is not speed: it is where the weight falls.

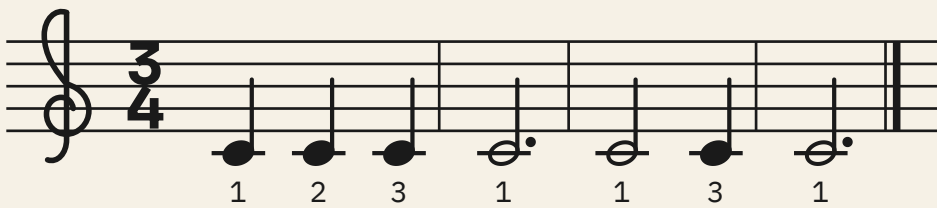


Figure 7.5 • Three four on the staff.

Four bars. The third bar holds a minim and a crotchet, which is two beats plus one, and the fourth holds a single note lasting all three.

CHAPTER 7 • TOPIC 7.5

Telling two from three by ear

The lesson

This is a checkpoint skill and it is easier than it sounds, provided you stop trying to count.

Do not count. **Conduct.** Move your hand down on every beat you feel is strong, and let the weak beats fill the gap. Your hand will settle into either a two pattern or a three pattern within about four bars, and then you look at what your hand is doing and read the answer off it.

The alternative method is to try to walk to the music. If walking fits comfortably, it is in two or four. If walking feels like it keeps arriving at the wrong moment, it is in three.

● LISTEN AGAIN

Your teacher plays six short extracts. For each one, conduct rather than count, and write two or three. Then swap: one pupil claps a metre and the class says which it was. Being the person who claps is harder and teaches you more.

■ YOUR TURN

- 1 What does the top number of a time signature tell you? And the bottom?
- 2 Write out the strong and weak pattern of two four, and of three four.
- 3 Why are marches usually in two rather than three?
- 4 Name two things March of the Gnomes does to sound small.

- 5 Bar this rhythm correctly in three four, drawing in the bar lines: crotchet, crotchet, crotchet, minim, crotchet, dotted minim.



- 6 A pupil writes a bar in three four containing a semibreve. What is wrong?

■ IN PERFORMANCE

Play March of the Gnomes twice for the class: once straight, once in character. Change nothing except your face and the weight of the first beat. Ask them which was which. If they cannot tell, you changed your intention without changing anything they could hear, and that is a useful thing to discover early.

■ GO FURTHER

Find a piece you already listen to and work out its metre by conducting. Then find one you cannot work out, and bring it to the lesson. The ones that resist are usually the interesting ones.

■ WHAT YOU CAN NOW DO

- ✓ Explain what the top and bottom numbers of a time signature mean.
- ✓ Describe the strong and weak pattern of two four and of three four.
- ✓ Play March of the Gnomes, and say what gives a march its character.
- ✓ Bar a given rhythm correctly in two four and in three four.
- ✓ Hear a piece and say whether it is in two or in three.

■ WORDS FOR THIS CHAPTER

time signature, metre, bar, strong beat, weak beat, two four, three four, march, waltz, conducting, character

Performing, and checkpoint two

The difference between playing something and being ready to perform it

THE QUESTION THIS CHAPTER ANSWERS

What is the difference between being able to play something and being ready to perform it?

IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL

- ✓ Bar The Train correctly in two four.
- ✓ Rehearse to a written plan rather than by playing it through.
- ✓ Start together and finish together with other players.
- ✓ Enter, set up, play, bow and leave in the right order.
- ✓ Say exactly what checkpoint two tests, and read your own result.

THE TOPICS

- 8.1 Barring The Train in two four
- 8.2 Rehearsing to a plan
- 8.3 Standing up in front of people
- 8.4 Checkpoint two



LISTEN AND LOOK

DSO Kids, Dallas Symphony Orchestra. Listening games from a working orchestra. Use them to practise hearing a pulse you could walk to.

www.dallassymphony.org/community-education/dso-kids/

Extension only, and not a substitute for the pages. Ask your teacher before you scan.

● BEFORE THE DOWNBEAT

You can play a piece perfectly in your bedroom and badly in a hall. Nothing about your hands has changed. Write down, in one sentence, what you think has.

CHAPTER 8 · TOPIC 8.1

Barring The Train in two four

The lesson

You have played The Train. Now you write it, which is a different skill, and the part that catches people is the **barring**.

Barring means putting the bar lines in the right places. You do it by arithmetic, not by eye: take the note values in order, add them up, and draw a bar line the moment the total reaches the number the time signature asks for. In two four that number is two.

Two rules follow, and both are absolute. A bar never holds more than its metre allows. A bar never holds less, unless it is the very first bar of a piece that begins before the first strong beat, which nothing in this book does.

◆ ADD UP BEFORE YOU DRAW

The commonest fault is drawing bar lines where they look right, evenly spaced across the page. Spacing is a matter of layout. Bar lines are a matter of arithmetic. Do the addition in the margin first.

CHAPTER 8 · TOPIC 8.2

Rehearsing to a plan

The lesson

Most pupils rehearse by playing the piece from the beginning until something goes wrong, going back to the beginning, and repeating. That is not rehearsal. It is performance with interruptions, and it guarantees that the opening is learned forty times better than the ending.

A rehearsal plan is written before you start and takes about a minute to make.

TIME	WHAT	WHY
3 min	Warm up: five fingers, then the piece slowly, once	The hands and the ears both need starting
8 min	The two bars that failed last time, alone, slowly	Named problems get the most time
4 min	The join either side of those bars	The join is where it will break in performance
4 min	Whole piece, twice, no stopping for anything	You are practising not stopping
1 min	Write down the two bars for next time	Next session starts already decided

Table 8.1 · A rehearsal plan for one twenty minute session.

Written down before you play a note. The point is that you decide what to work on while you are calm, rather than while you are frustrated.

Notice the fourth row. Playing through **without stopping for anything** is a skill of its own, and it has to be practised deliberately, because everything else in your practice has trained you to stop and fix.

CHAPTER 8 · TOPIC 8.3

Standing up in front of people

The lesson

Your hands are the same. What changes in a hall is that you can hear the room, you can see people, and your body has decided that this matters. A faster heart and shallower breathing are not fear, they are preparation, and every performer alive has them.

You cannot argue yourself calm, but you can change the breathing, because that is physiology rather than confidence. Two slow breaths, out for longer than in, before you sit down. It works on everybody.

Then there is a sequence, and having a sequence is most of what makes a performance feel controlled from the inside.

- ➊ **Walk on** without hurrying. Slower than feels natural.
- ➋ **Set up**: adjust the bench, place the music, put your hands in position.
- ➌ **Wait**. Two seconds of stillness. This is the part everybody skips and the part that tells the audience something is about to happen.
- ➍ **Breathe in**, and start on that breath.
- ➎ **Play**, and if something goes wrong, keep going. An audience cannot tell a wrong note from a right one nearly as well as it can tell a stop from a continuation.
- ➏ **Finish**, and stay still until the sound has actually stopped.
- ➐ **Stand, bow, leave**. Look at them while you bow. It is a thank you, not an apology.

● ON YOUR FEET

Rehearse steps 1 to 7 with no instrument at all. Walk on, set up an imaginary keyboard, wait, breathe, mime eight bars, hold the silence, stand, bow, walk off. Do it three times each. It feels ridiculous and it removes about half of what goes wrong on the night.

CHAPTER 8 · TOPIC 8.4

Checkpoint two

The lesson

Checkpoint two takes a triple lesson and has three equal parts. Nothing in it is a surprise.

PART	WHAT IT ASKS	TAUGHT IN
Written	Time signatures, barring in two four and three four, note values	Chapters 7 and 8
Performance	One prepared piece, played to the class, with the full entrance sequence	Chapters 6 and 8
Listening	Telling two from three by ear	Chapter 7

Table 8.2 · What checkpoint two covers, and where it was taught.

If a row is unfamiliar, you know exactly which pages to return to.

The performance section is not marked mostly on notes. It is marked on whether the pulse was steady, whether you kept going, and whether you did the seven steps. A performance with one wrong note and no hesitation scores above a performance with every note right and three stops, because the first is music and the second is practice.

■ YOUR TURN

- 1 What does barring mean, and how do you decide where a bar line goes?
- 2 Why does a rehearsal plan work better than playing the piece from the start?
- 3 List the seven steps of the entrance sequence, in order.

- 4 Why does slow breathing help before a performance, when telling yourself to relax does not?
- 5 Tick honestly: I can play my piece from start to finish without stopping to correct anything.

■ IN PERFORMANCE

Run each other's performance test the day before the real one, sitting where the teacher will sit. Mark it out of ten for steadiness alone and name one thing that would raise it. Being the examiner for ten minutes teaches you more about what is wanted than any amount of being examined.

■ WHAT YOU CAN NOW DO

- ✓ Bar The Train correctly in two four.
- ✓ Rehearse to a written plan rather than by playing it through.
- ✓ Start together and finish together with other players.
- ✓ Enter, set up, play, bow and leave in the right order.
- ✓ Say exactly what checkpoint two tests, and read your own result.

— WORDS FOR THIS CHAPTER

barring, bar line, rehearsal plan, run-through, entrance, bow, steadiness, checkpoint, sight-reading

The play

A script gives you the words and hides everything else

THE QUESTION THIS CHAPTER ANSWERS

What does a script give you that a piece of music does not, and what does it leave out?

IN THIS CHAPTER, YOU WILL

- ✓ Read a play and work out what is happening from the dialogue.
- ✓ Say what your character wants and what is in their way.
- ✓ Learn lines by cue rather than by staring at the page.
- ✓ Recover out loud when you or somebody else drops a line.
- ✓ Block a scene so that every actor can be seen and heard.

THE TOPICS

- 18.1 Reading a play for the first time
- 18.2 The play: The Night the Piano Went Missing
- 18.3 Learning lines, and what to do when you lose one
- 18.4 Blocking: where everybody stands, and why



LISTEN AND LOOK

Victoria and Albert Museum, Theatre and Performance. Costumes, set models and photographs from real productions. Look for how a performer's body tells you who they are before they speak.

www.vam.ac.uk/collections/theatre-performance

Extension only, and not a substitute for the pages. Ask your teacher before you scan.

● BEFORE THE DOWNBEAT

Think of the last time something went badly wrong in front of other people: a match, a presentation, a family lunch. Who took charge, and how did you know they had? Write one sentence. This chapter is about a group of pupils to whom something goes very wrong ninety minutes before a concert, and the play works only if the audience can see, without being told, who is deciding what happens next.

CHAPTER 18 · TOPIC 18.1

Reading a play for the first time

The lesson

A script gives you two things and hides everything else. It gives you the **words** and it gives you the **order** they are said in. It does not give you the tone, the speed, the distance between two people, what anyone is doing with their hands, or what any of them actually want. All of that is your job, and it is why ten companies can perform the same script and produce ten different evenings.

So the first read is not a performance. It is an investigation. Read the whole thing through once, out loud, sitting down, badly, without acting. Then answer four questions about it before anybody stands up.

- ❶ **What does each person want?** Not in general: in this scene, from the person in front of them. A character who wants nothing cannot be played.
- ❷ **What is in the way?** A scene is somebody trying to get something and something preventing it. If nothing is in the way, there is no scene.
- ❸ **Where does it turn?** Almost every scene has one moment after which it cannot go back. Find the line.
- ❹ **What has just happened?** Nobody in a play walks on from nowhere. Decide what each character was doing thirty seconds before their entrance, and they will walk on differently.

◆ **DO NOT DECIDE YOUR VOICE FIRST**

The commonest mistake at this age is to choose a funny voice in the first reading and then spend three weeks defending it. Work out what the character wants first. The voice follows from that, and it will be better than anything you invented on day one.

CHAPTER 18 · TOPIC 18.2

The play: The Night the Piano Went Missing

The lesson

This is the play your class will perform. It is written for this course: it has twelve speaking parts, it can absorb any number of non-speaking musicians, and every piece of music in it is a piece you have learned this year. It runs about fifteen minutes.

Read the whole thing before you read anything about how to stage it.

PART	WHO THEY ARE	WHAT THEY WANT
MATILDE	Year 9, plays the keyboard, has organised everything	The concert to happen exactly as planned
RODRIGO	Year 9, plays percussion, cheerful, unhurried	Everybody to calm down
INES	Year 9, sings, nervous, very well prepared	Not to have to sing without accompaniment
TOMAS	Year 9, plays recorder, arrived late	To be forgiven for arriving late
BEATRIZ	Year 8, violin, new to the school	To be given something to do
VASCO	Year 9, has a torch and opinions	To be the one who solves it
LEONOR	Year 9, stage manager, holds the running order	The running order to survive contact with people
DUARTE	Year 9, lights, mostly silent	To be asked before anything is switched on
CAROLINA	Year 9, plays flute, sceptical	The truth about what happened
AFONSO	Year 7, small, keeps being sent on errands	To stop being sent on errands
SENHOR NOGUEIRA	The caretaker, sixty, unbothered	To go home at nineteen hundred
PROFESSORA SAMPAIO	The music teacher	The pupils to solve it themselves

Table 18.1 • The cast, and what each of them wants.

Copy this table into your book with your own name beside your part, and fill in the last column yourself after the first read. If two of you write the same answer in that column, one of you has not read carefully enough.

Scene one: the hall, 17:40

The school hall in Oeiras. Chairs in rows. A music stand, a chair with a violin case on it, cables. Where the piano should be there is a rectangle of clean floor in a dusty room. LEONOR is holding a clipboard. MATILDE is standing in the rectangle.

MATILDE. It was here on Tuesday.

LEONOR. It was here at lunchtime.

MATILDE. Then where is it?

LEONOR. *(reading)* Seventeen forty. Doors at half past six. That gives us fifty minutes and I have a running order that begins with a piano.

RODRIGO comes in eating something.

RODRIGO. Has anyone seen the piano?

MATILDE. Rodrigo.

RODRIGO. I am only asking.

MATILDE. We are aware that the piano is missing. We are past the asking stage.

RODRIGO. Right. What stage are we at?

Pause. Nobody knows.

LEONOR. We are at the stage where somebody says something useful.

INES comes in, sees the space, and stops.

INES. No.

MATILDE. Ines.

INES. No. I sing second. I sing second with the piano. That is the entire arrangement.

RODRIGO. You could sing without it.

INES. I could also walk to Lisbon.

Scene two: the same, 17:55

VASCO comes in with a torch, switched on, in a fully lit room. CAROLINA follows.

VASCO. Nobody touch anything.

CAROLINA. It is a piano, Vasco. It is not a crime scene.

VASCO. Somebody moved a piano out of a locked hall in ninety minutes. That is either four strong adults or one person with a key.

CAROLINA. Or it is on wheels.

Silence.

VASCO. *(not conceding anything)* Or it is on wheels.

AFONSO runs in, out of breath.

AFONSO. I have been to the staff room, the gym and the library.

LEONOR. And?

AFONSO. And nobody has a piano. Can I stop now?

MATILDE. No. Go and ask Senhor Nogueira.

AFONSO. *(going)* I asked Senhor Nogueira first. He said he goes home at seven.

TOMAS comes in, late, holding a recorder case.

TOMAS. Sorry. The bus. I know. Sorry.

MATILDE. The piano has gone.

TOMAS. *(sitting down, relieved)* Then it is not the worst thing that has happened this evening.

BEATRIZ is standing at the edge with her violin case, waiting to be noticed. Nobody notices her. PROFESSORA SAMPAIO comes in, looks at the empty rectangle, and says nothing at all. LEONOR looks at her.

LEONOR. Are you going to fix it?

PROFESSORA SAMPAIO. No.

LEONOR. Why not?

PROFESSORA SAMPAIO. Because in fourteen years nobody has learned anything from me fixing it. *(She sits down in the audience.)* Doors are at half past six.

SENHOR NOGUEIRA appears in the doorway with a mug.

SENHOR NOGUEIRA. It is in the gym.

Everybody turns.

MATILDE. The gym.

SENHOR NOGUEIRA. They wanted it for the assembly on Thursday. I moved it Tuesday. It is on wheels.

CAROLINA. *(to VASCO)* It is on wheels.

SENHOR NOGUEIRA. I finish at seven. The gym door is the narrow one. It does not go through the narrow one. I did tell somebody. *(He goes.)*

RODRIGO. He told somebody.

LEONOR. He told nobody.

MATILDE. *(flat)* We have thirty minutes and a piano in a room it cannot leave.

Scene three: the same, 18:10

Nobody speaks for a moment. Then BEATRIZ, who has not spoken at all, puts her case down on a chair and opens it.

BEATRIZ. How many pieces are in the concert?

LEONOR. *(surprised to be addressed)* Six.

BEATRIZ. How many of them are actually about the piano?

LEONOR looks at the running order properly for the first time.

LEONOR. Two.

BEATRIZ. Then four of them are not.

MATILDE. Ines sings with the piano.

BEATRIZ. Ines could sing with a violin.

INES. I have never sung with a violin.

BEATRIZ. I have never played for anybody in this school. We would be even.

A pause. INES looks at her.

INES. Do you know it?

BEATRIZ. Sing four bars.

INES sings four bars, unaccompanied and slightly under her breath.

MUSIC CUE 1. BEATRIZ plays the same four bars back on the violin, or the class instrument the part has been given to. It should be plain and correct rather than impressive.

INES. *(quietly)* All right.

RODRIGO. So we are doing it.

MATILDE. We are doing four of six.

LEONOR. Five. Tomas can take the piano part on the recorder if somebody holds the beat.

TOMAS. Somebody being?

RODRIGO. *(raising a drum)* Somebody being me. I have been trying to be useful for twenty minutes.

VASCO. And the sixth?

Everybody looks at the empty rectangle.

MATILDE. The sixth is the one everybody knows.

CAROLINA. Then everybody sings it.

MATILDE. The audience as well.

LEONOR. *(writing)* I am putting that on the running order and I am not telling them until it happens.

AFONSO. *(arriving, exhausted)* The gym is locked.

MATILDE. We know. Afonso, you are on stage tonight.

AFONSO. Doing what?

MATILDE. Standing at the front and starting number six.

AFONSO. By myself?

PROFESSORA SAMPAIO. *(from the audience, not moving)* Nobody starts anything by themselves. That is what the other eleven are for.

DUARTE, *who has said nothing for the whole play, walks to the lighting board.*

DUARTE. Am I allowed to switch these on now?

LEONOR. Yes.

DUARTE. Thank you.

He brings the lights up. The hall becomes a stage.

MUSIC CUE 2. *The full company performs one piece from this year's work, in whatever arrangement the class has actually rehearsed. It is played straight, without comedy. The play ends on the last note, and the lights go out on it rather than after it.*

END

● FROM THE WINGS

The instruction "the lights go out on the last note rather than after it" is worth arguing about. A blackout that lands exactly on a final chord tells an audience the piece is finished and that somebody planned it. A blackout half a second late tells them somebody was watching for the end. That half second is the difference between a school concert and a production, and it costs nothing.

CHAPTER 18 · TOPIC 18.3

Learning lines, and what to do when you lose one

The lesson

Lines are not learned by staring at them. They are learned by connecting each one to the line before it, so that the other person's words become the reason yours arrive.

The method that works, in order:

- 1 **Learn your cues, not your speeches.** Cover your own lines and read the other parts aloud. You need to recognise the last three words before you speak more than you need to recite your own paragraph.
- 2 **Learn them standing up and moving.** Memory attaches to the body. Lines learned sitting still tend to disappear the moment you have to walk.

- 3 **Learn the meaning, not the sound.** If you can say in your own words what your character is trying to get in this speech, you can recover the line even if the exact words go.
- 4 **Little and often.** Ten minutes a day for two weeks beats three hours on the Sunday before.

When you lose a line, and you will. Do not stop. Do not look at the wings. Do not apologise. Stay in character and do the next thing your character would do, which is usually to want the same thing again in different words. The audience knows the story, not the script, and they cannot tell that a sentence is missing unless somebody on stage tells them by panicking.

If a fellow actor dries, give them their next cue inside your own line. That is what an ensemble is for, and it is why you learned the whole scene rather than your own bits of it.

● ON YOUR FEET

In pairs, run scene two twice. The first time, deliberately drop a line somewhere in the middle and let your partner rescue you. The second time, swap. Practising the recovery is the only way to make it calm on the night, and a class that has never rehearsed a mistake will treat the first one as a catastrophe.

CHAPTER 18 · TOPIC 18.4

Blocking: where everybody stands, and why

The lesson

Blocking is the plan of where every performer is at every moment. It is written down, it is agreed in rehearsal, and it is not improvised on the night.

Four rules cover almost everything at this level.

- **Be seen.** If the audience cannot see your face, they will stop listening within about ten seconds, however well you are speaking.

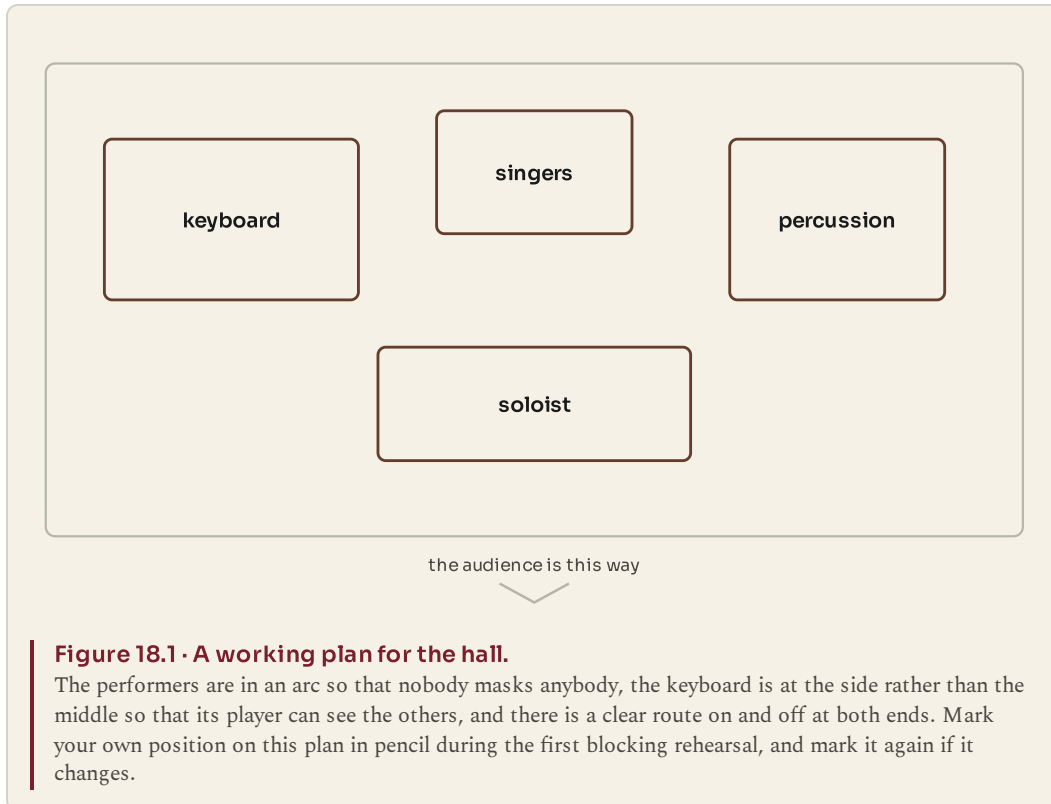
- **Do not mask.** You mask somebody when you stand between them and the audience. Check constantly, because the person you are masking cannot see that you are doing it.

- **Open out.** Stand at a slight angle to the person you are speaking to rather

than square on, so that both of you are half turned towards the room.

- **Move on your own line, not on somebody else's.** Movement pulls the eye. If

you cross the stage while another actor is speaking, the audience watches you and stops hearing them.



■ YOUR TURN

- 1 Name the two things a script gives you and three things it does not.
- 2 For your own part, write in one sentence what your character wants in scene two.
- 3 Find the line in scene three after which the play cannot go back to how it was. Write the line out and say why you chose it.
- 4 Why does this book tell you to learn your cues rather than your speeches?
- 5 What should you do if the actor opposite you forgets a line?
- 6 What does it mean to mask another performer, and why can they not fix it themselves?

■ IN PERFORMANCE

Senhor Nogueira has eleven lines and is the person who solves the plot. Small parts are not small jobs. Play him as somebody who genuinely does not think this is an emergency, because he has seen forty concerts and knows they all happen, and the scene becomes funny without anybody trying to be funny.

— GO FURTHER

Rewrite the last page so that the piano is found in time. Then read both endings aloud and decide which is the better play, and why. Most people find the original is better, and working out the reason teaches you more about drama than any definition would.

■ THE REHEARSAL

Cast the play, read it round the table once, then block scene three only, on your feet, using the plan above. Do not attempt the whole play in one session. Finish by running scene three twice without stopping, including the music cue. Write the blocking into your own book as you go, because a blocking that lives only in somebody's memory is not a blocking.

■ WHAT YOU CAN NOW DO

- ✓ Read a play and work out what is happening from the dialogue alone.
- ✓ Say what your character wants and what is in their way.
- ✓ Learn lines by cue rather than by staring at the page.
- ✓ Recover out loud when you or somebody else drops a line.
- ✓ Block a scene so that every performer can be seen and heard.

■ WORDS FOR THIS CHAPTER

script, dialogue, stage direction, cast, character, objective, cue, dries, blocking, masking, opening out, ensemble, running order, blackout, music cue